Realist Absurdist Perfectionism: Meaning After the Death of God

Commentary 1

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Argument

This essay examines whether life retains meaning after the death of God. Nietzsche's proclamation, though often caricatured, was in his eyes a catastrophe: he feared that a secularizing Europe, left with nothing on which to hang its spiritual hats, would slide into Nihilism. The theistic view that a creator sets each life's meaning is not dismissed, but a meaning imposed by an external force and accepted on its authority, rather than examined and logically derived, is inherited on someone else's terms. Nietzsche's fear, while not irrational, was overstated, as human history moves in cycles and rarely spirals to unrecoverable depths. Pessimistic Nihilism is bleak but is not the only form Nihilism takes, and existentialist self-created meaning fails for want of any hierarchy or grounding. Absurdism proves the most tenable position, with one qualification: if life has no meaning and our task is to revolt against the absurd, then the greatest revolt is the unending striving for perfection. This position, Realist Absurdist Perfectionism, is held to be the most attractive, supportable, and logical response to the question of meaning.

"God is dead. God remains dead. And we have killed him."

— Nietzsche[1]

An often caricatured quote, adopted by atheists, intellectuals, and edgy teenagers alike. It is certainly a blunt yet thought-provoking statement that many theists revile, which,

[1]Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Gay Science*, trans. J. Nauckhoff (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006), §125, originally published 1882.

ironically enough, is often the reason self-declared contrarians quote it at every conference and lunch-in they attend. It has been the badge of adolescent rebellion against conservative grandparents for generations, and yet this cliché reading has made it perhaps one of the most misunderstood quotations in existentialist literature, which is a pity, because it captures the dynamic of a historical moment, in this case late nineteenth-century Europe. Nietzsche was not a Marxist, nor did he wish to tear down the walls of St. Peter's Basilica or exhume long-dead popes and force them to stand trial to satisfy his ego.[2] He saw the death of God as an unfortunate reality and a catastrophe. With people having nothing on which to hang their spiritual hats in an increasingly secular world, Nietzsche feared, as his horrified madman shows, that it was only a matter of time, if left unchecked, before the world moved hard into Nihilism. Nietzsche did not, of course, mean that a literal God had physically died; that is an extrapolation some misled readers draw, but it was not his intent in writing *The Gay Science*. Western civilization was, however, gradually distancing itself from strict religious adherence and traditional moral frameworks. We see this shift in our society today, and it recurs throughout history: stringent religious periods are often followed by periods of reform. This is nothing new.

People throughout time have believed in the supernatural and in spiritual deities. Every civilization has had its gods, and yet conclusive evidence of any deity's physical existence remains elusive. Traditional religious individuals will likely hold that a divine creator set both a specific meaning for each individual and a collective meaning for society. This tends to be the strongest version of their argument. Two things must be clarified before continuing. First, this essay will neither dismiss any argument nor speculate on personal and societal motives. Any analysis of why people bend the knee to religion and religious frameworks would be hearsay at best and ad hominem at worst. Second, in analytic philosophy the question of meaning is often viewed with immense skepticism. A. J. Ayer, for instance, held the question of life's meaning to be literally meaningless, since no possible observation could verify an answer, while Ogden and Richards, in *The Meaning of Meaning*, observe that the phrase "the meaning of life" usually places meaning in the purpose of some will or design (their definition VII(b)), or else treats meaning as significance, a thing's place within some larger system (their definition VIII).[3] For simplicity, this essay takes meaning in the first of these senses: the main purpose, or one of the main purposes, with which and toward which

[2]In January 897, at what became known as the Cadaver Synod, Pope Stephen VI had the corpse of his predecessor, Pope Formosus, exhumed, dressed in papal vestments, and put on trial; the dead pope was found guilty and his acts as pope declared void.

[3]C. K. Ogden and I. A. Richards, *The Meaning of Meaning* (New York: Harcourt, Brace & World, Harvest Book edition), 196; originally published 1923.

an individual lives their life.

Returning to the theist argument, the objection often raised against it is that a meaning set upon you, even by a deity, cannot be truly yours. This seems intuitive on the surface, but it runs counter to how society usually views individual possession, which is why some find this depiction of meaning hard to abandon and others find it equally hard to adopt. If I give you a pack of gum, the pack of gum is now yours. Some may view meaning in the same light. There is, however, an issue with that view. The purpose of gifting or possessing a pack of gum is the consumption of the gum (unless you collect packs of gum and display them, which is a different matter). Meaning is not something to be consumed; it is a driver. That is, meaning drives subsequent action. The end goal of meaning is further action, whereas the end goal of a pack of gum is consumption. You consume gum until it no longer provides any utility; you do not consume meaning. Because meaning drives further action, if it is not individually synthesized, an individual could end up living their life in support of ends they did not decide to support. This is not inherently bad; in fact, it is quite common. Values are inherited, and some people float through life striving toward goals and values they have neither examined nor set. The argument can be stated more rigorously. First, the theistic view offers a universal meaning, which is not inherently wrong; it is perhaps the view's strongest defense against relativistic meaning, and it is shared by many other sound theories of meaning. Second, in the theistic view that meaning is imposed by an external force and accepted on that force's authority, not logically derived. (It can be both logically derived and accepted on authority, but then the argument for meaning rests on two foundations at once, which allows an individual to conceal which of the two actually validates their meaning.) Third, and following from the second, meaning here is not examined and brought into one's own drives; it is inherited, logically or not, on someone else's terms. The argument is valid, but its soundness remains open, since one could claim to hold a meaning both on another's authority and after logical examination. That claim may be true, but it can also mask a lack of critical thinking about one's own meaning and serve as an excuse for acting on authority alone.

The larger point, in relation to what Nietzsche feared at the end of the nineteenth century, is that without religion, masses of people presume their lives have lost meaning. This fear should not be straw-manned as stupidity or fanaticism, and the argument above in no way disproves theism; it simply raises questions that show how theistic arguments, especially dogmatic ones, are dangerous if not thoroughly questioned and individually bought into. As individuals began to analyze their personal beliefs at the end of the 1800s, however, many were driven away from theism, and Nietzsche worried that without God there would indeed be no divine meaning to each person's life. Some individuals experience this lack of objectivity

as an existential crisis of meaning, which Nietzsche feared would lead to Nihilism. This fear was not irrational, but it was misattributed and perhaps scapegoated as the ultimate destruction of humanity as we know it, when in reality the danger is less drastic and the nuances of this areligious development are more complex. This is largely because human history is largely cyclical: as established, periods of religious fervor are eventually met with periods of non-religious movement, just as periods of war are eventually met with periods of peace, and droughts with floods. On a global or societal level, when extrapolated to generalities, humanity rarely spirals to unrecoverable depths. This is not to say the course of human events never changes, but that it changes only minorly in proportion to larger trends. Women gaining the right to vote was not a minor development in American history, and it was a new freedom for American women at that time, but the pattern has been seen before: periods of oppression followed by slight reforms, or in other cases by massive upheavals such as the French Revolutions of 1789 and 1848, each of which eventually gave way to an emperor named Napoleon, the first in 1804 and his nephew, Napoleon III, in 1852, whose rule in turn cleared the way for further revolution. There is evidence of this in religious cases too, such as the Protestant Reformation, which arose from church abuses made possible by the Church's almost total power in Western Europe, and the Enlightenment, which followed the long era of church-centered society and the wars of religion that came after the Reformation. The idea behind these examples is that a period dominated by one social force, whether a religion-centered society or a revolution, often breeds a countermovement, driving the cyclical movement of human events. This is not an exposé on human history; scholars such as Ibn Khaldun and Arnold J. Toynbee have developed cyclical accounts of it at length.

Either way, Nietzsche was correct that the spread of purely despairing Nihilism is a cause for concern, but not to the magnitude that *The Gay Science* and *The Will to Power* suggest. (It should be noted that *The Will to Power* was compiled posthumously by Nietzsche's perhaps less than well-intentioned sister, Elisabeth Förster-Nietzsche, and was later used to portray him as a supporter of Nazism, a claim incompatible with his philosophy and a gross mischaracterization of his work.)

Secular thinkers have interpreted meaning in many different ways, as theists have; for clarity, only one theistic argument is outlined above, and this essay does not mean to suggest that theists hold only one doctrine concerning meaning. Nonetheless, as Nietzsche predicted, many thinkers and individuals did adopt Nihilism, among them influential figures such as Emil Cioran, who wrote extensively in support of pessimistic Nihilism in works such as *The Trouble with Being Born*.[4] It is interesting to note that most pessimistic Nihilists treat death

[4]E. M. Cioran, *The Trouble with Being Born*, trans. Richard Howard (New York: Seaver Books, 1976), originally published 1973.

as the coming tragedy, while Cioran held that birth was the real offense to humanity: a bleak and, in my opinion, unconvincing view, yet a substantial one in Nihilist thought. Pessimistic Nihilism in all its forms, not simply Cioran's, is widely criticized as untenable, bleak, and oppressive, and Nietzsche says the following on the subject:

> "Not only the belief that everything deserves to perish; but one actually puts one's shoulder to the plough; one destroys."[5]

Nietzsche's view is rhetorically convincing, but it does not go so far as to disprove Nihilism, and there are several nuances here worth noting. Nihilism is rightly associated with the view that life is meaningless, but it is further burdened with the assumption that this implies a depressing worldview. That does not always follow. Some Nihilists, like Cioran, are notoriously pessimistic and hopeless; it is unfair, however, to depict other branches of Nihilism as such, and doing so risks the arguer's credibility. There are strands of Nihilistic thought, sometimes called "sunny" or "optimistic" Nihilism, in which the meaninglessness of life is viewed as the ultimate freedom from the burden of knowing you may not fulfill your meaning. (The term is a recent one, from Wendy Syfret's *The Sunny Nihilist*, a popular rather than an academic work.)[6] Nevertheless, Nihilism as a whole is still often depicted as passive, and the philosopher and mathematician Bertrand Russell offers his answer to this in *The Conquest of Happiness*:

> "The universe may be as meaningless as it seems. But there is no reason why man should not make it better while he is here."[7]

This is, of course, a noble intent, and many individuals do live actively trying to make society better while they are here. Yet this is the exact spot where many individuals and thinkers alike fall prey to assuming that Nihilism means you must despair and simply exist in sloth, which is precisely what Russell argues against in the passage above. They assume, too, that if the theistic argument doesn't align with their self-examined values and fails to offer an individually justified meaning, they must make their own meaning, often referred to as existentialist meaning. Jean-Paul Sartre, the French existentialist, puts it this way:

> "Man is condemned to be free."[8]

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[5]Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Will to Power*, trans. W. Kaufmann and R. J. Hollingdale (New York: Vintage International, 1974), originally compiled posthumously 1901.

[6]Wendy Syfret, *The Sunny Nihilist: How a Meaningless Life Can Make You Truly Happy* (London: Souvenir Press, 2021).

[7]Bertrand Russell, *The Conquest of Happiness* (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1930).

[8]Jean-Paul Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, trans. C. Macomber (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2007), originally delivered as a lecture in 1945.

And in this condemnation lies absolute responsibility. To illustrate this, consider the following analogy: if an enjoyable movie is playing and you suddenly realize it must end, would you simply stop watching? No; you have given that movie value by choosing to watch it. We can, the existentialist argues, do the same with life. We choose what we buy into, what we believe, and how we live our lives. This is noble in principle, but it leaves open an unsettling possibility. Someone might decide that their meaning is to kill as many people as possible, or to steal as much as possible. The laws of society prevent them from doing so without punishment, but this framework of meaning does not. In the same vein, an individual could decide that their meaning is to eat as many potato chips as possible while moving as little as possible. The issue with self-created meaning is that there is no hierarchy of meaning: any meaning is valid unless parameters are introduced to constrain it, and if they are, the meaning is no longer freely created, because external conditions have entered the decision.

There is another strand of thought that grows out of the Nihilist camp but does not share its commonly assumed passivity or hopeless despair: Absurdism. Like Nihilism, it holds that life has no objective, subjective, or self-imposed meaning. Albert Camus, however, in *The Myth of Sisyphus* and *The Rebel*, attempts to move beyond Nihilism. He argues, along with other absurdists, that the best answer to the question of meaning begins with recognizing the universe as a cold, unforgiving, uncaring entity, and humanity as a tiny development on an insignificant planet, and ends in total revolt against this fact by living defiantly in the face of the absurd. Instead of despairing at what absurdists call the absurd, individuals embrace the irony of their situation; they are tasked with recognizing the pointlessness of their circumstances while still going about their daily practices regardless of the universe's indifference, and it is from this that Camus derives his idea of revolt.

Personally, I do not perfectly subscribe to any of these camps. With one qualification, however, Absurdism is the one I find most tenable. The qualification is that, rather than simply surviving and going about one's daily tasks as rebellion, individuals strive for excellence in everything they do, maximizing personal capacity in every act and every interaction. This will never actually be achieved, as it is essentially perfectionism; but perfection is not the goal of this strand of thought. The goal is the striving: the recognition of the absurd and of the fact that you will fall short, and the continued striving for excellence, growth, and development in the face of both. To a careful reader, it may seem that I have fallen into the same trap as the existentialists. Sartre's problem, however, is that his meaning is not grounded. Along with the ability to choose your own meaning comes the ability to switch it at any time. If saving lives were your meaning, you could, to avoid going to a disaster zone, declare that today your meaning is to watch television, and tomorrow you will return to saving lives. My solution does not fall prey to that trap, as it follows logically from Absurdist

principles. Nor is it caught by the issue raised against Sartre, because this theory does not claim to create a meaning at all; life remains without one, and this is simply the best way to revolt against that fact, for if we are to revolt, we ought to do it as well as it can be done. What revolt against the absurd could be greater than utter striving for perfection? To rebel against the absurd, as cliché as it might be, one must use the absurd, and what is more absurd than this: your life has no meaning, yet everything you do, you do with greatness and perfection as your intent. Camus argues in a different direction, placing the quantity of experience above its quality, but I disagree. To use his own example against him, take Sisyphus. What would be more absurd than Sisyphus not only rolling the boulder happily up the mountain for eternity, but doing so with perfect form, sculpting both himself and the rock that is his burden into their greatest possible forms? That is the key to this entire exercise in meaning: so long as a an answer to the issue of meaning is not entirely subjective and follows logically from elevating human agency, or, as Aristotle would say, human flourishing, it is a valid response to the absence of meaning. Nietzsche offers what he presents as the solution to the question of the meaning of life in a similarly valid way, holding that radical self-overcoming is the key to a meaningful existence. This is effective, and my position is essentially a synthesis of Nietzsche, Aristotle, and Thomas Hurka's *Perfectionism*, in which Hurka holds that a good human life is one spent developing one's capabilities.[9] In summary: Realist, the recognition that perfection is impossible to achieve; Absurdist, the view that life is meaningless and that we must face the absurdity of our existence daily; Perfectionist, the striving for the maximum elevation of human agency and capability. This, then, is what I hold to be the most attractive, supportable, and logical position concerning the question of meaning.

[9]Thomas Hurka, *Perfectionism* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993).